

The Significance of the Racak Massacre

Paper 1 Sample

Prescribed subject 5: Conflict and intervention

Read sources Q to T and answer questions 17 to 20. The sources and questions relate to case study 2: Kosovo (1989–2002): Ethnic cleansing and crimes against humanity; significance of the Račak massacre.

Source Q

A photograph of a destroyed village showing a mosque and houses. (15th June 1999).



Source R

US ambassador William Walker in an interview with the US Public Broadcasting Company. Walker was the head of the Kosovo Verification Mission (KVM), deployed between October 1998 and March 1999. Walker was one of the first eyewitnesses of the aftermath of the Račak massacre. (2010).

. . . Late in the afternoon, January 15, [I was] informed that a military clash had taken place by a village called Račak. Next morning, on January 16, my deputy, myself, my interpreter, and a whole bunch of journalists went out to Račak. We came out of the village and after about 500 yards, we came across the first body. It was a man's body. He was obviously an old man.

We started up the hill again, and every 15 or 20 yards, there was another body, all in sorts of grotesque postures. There was no sign of uniforms or weapons. They were killed where they lay, bullets were in their bodies, in their eyes, and in the tops of their heads. There was no way this could have been faked.

I talked to some of my people who'd been there, and to some of the journalists. Then I talked to some of the villagers. All the stories were very consistent...the village was surrounded by the army...they herded the women and the small children into the mosque and rounded up the men and boys. In mid-afternoon, they marched the men and boys off.

Nothing I saw on the hill had anything in common with the government's first story, which was that there was a clash with uniformed, armed KLA, and that 15 had been killed. Everything I saw was consistent with what the villagers were telling me, less than 24 hours after it had happened, which was that the government had come in there and done this. The government was already putting out stories that uniforms had been taken off, and other clothes put on. The stories got more and more fanciful as the days progressed.

Source S

R Craig Nation, a professor of Russian and Eurasian Studies, writing in the academic book 'War in the Balkans' 1991–2002 (2003).

The question of what exactly happened in Račak has been hotly contested. The version of events announced to the world in the immediate aftermath of the killing suggested that Serbian units in pursuit of a small KLA contingent occupied the village and massacred its inhabitants as an admonition to those tempted to offer sanctuary to the guerillas. One of the first international observers to arrive on the scene was former US ambassador William Walker, now serving as head of the KVM force. Upon viewing the corpses of the victims, Walker flew into a rage, accusing the Serbian side of conducting a wilful massacre, and announcing his convictions via telephone to US leaders... Broadcast around the world, Walker's judgement went far to condition public sentiment for an eventual military campaign against Serbia. Within days, the US Department of State would condemn the event as a 'massacre of civilians by Serb security forces,' while NATO Secretary General Solana spoke of 'a flagrant violation of international humanitarian law.'

Source T

Y Andre Hodzic, a political scientist, writing in the academic book 'Conflict and ethnic cleansing in the Balkans.' 2015.

On January 15, the Kosovo Verification Mission (KVM), an unarmed observer force, received reports of civilian casualties in the village of Račak. Access to the broader vicinity of Račak was granted the following day, January 16. Accompanied by foreign journalists and members of the European Union's Kosovo Diplomatic Observer Mission, KVM personnel found 40 bodies within and around the village. Reports suggested that an additional five bodies had been retrieved by families, bringing the total to 45 fatalities. Among the dead were a 12-year-old boy and three women, with all victims bearing gunshot wounds; some were found decapitated.

The head of the KVM, William Walker, provided a grim account of the scene. He characterized the events as "an unspeakable atrocity" and "a crime very much against humanity," directly accusing Serbian security forces and demanding accountability for those responsible. Several journalists and other observers present corroborated the findings with first-hand accounts and held the Serbs responsible.

On January 18, Louise Arbour, Chief Prosecutor of the International Criminal Tribunal for the Former Yugoslavia (ICTY), attempted to investigate the killings but was denied entry into Kosovo by Serbian authorities.

Questions

- 17 a) What, according to Source R, had happened at Račak on 15th January 1999? [3 marks]
- 17 b) What does Source Q reveal about the conflict in Kosovo? [2 marks]
18. With reference to its origin, purpose and content, analyse the value and limitations of Source R for an historian studying the Račak massacre. [4 marks]
19. Compare and contrast what Sources S and T reveal about the Račak massacre and the immediate response to it. [6 marks]
20. Using the sources and your own knowledge, discuss how the Račak massacre was a turning point in the conflict in Kosovo.

Conflict and Intervention: The Significance of the Racak Massacre Student Answer

Question 17[a]

What, according to Source R, had happened at Račak on 15 January 1999?

Firstly, Source R says that the village had been surrounded by the Serb army. Secondly, it says that the women and small children had been 'herded' into a mosque. Finally, the source says that the men and boys were then 'rounded up' and marched off. The source also talks about dead bodies in the village, and so the implication is that the men and boys had then been killed.

3/3 Clear, concise, and complete summary showing accurate understanding of the key events described in the source. Meets all criteria for top-band response.

[b] What does Source Q reveal about the conflict in Kosovo?

Source Q reveals that there was physical destruction of both houses and mosques. The photo shows rubble and an empty space where a building would have been indicating that this destruction would also have led to people having to leave the area as they would not have been able to carry on living there. This is supported by the fact that there are no people to be seen in the photo.

2/2 Accurately interprets visual evidence, providing both factual observation and reasonable inference about the human impact of conflict.

18. With reference to its origin, purpose and content, analyse the value and limitations of Source R for an historian studying the Račak massacre.

Source R is an interview with the US ambassador by the US Public Broadcasting Company and the origin has value for an historian studying the massacre as Walker would have been someone who understood the conflict due to his position (US ambassador and head of KVM force), and could be expected to report accurately on what he saw. The US were not combatants in the conflict so we could expect him to be an impartial observer. He also visited the scene fewer than 24 hours after the conflict had happened so he was able to provide an eye-witness account of the situation on the ground before bodies were removed, and to interview witnesses before details became forgotten. His observations about the scene are quite detailed.

Nevertheless, there are also limitations to the source. The purpose of William Walker could be questioned. He may be exaggerating what he saw in order to justify the US military response which followed his report on the massacre. The fact that this is a television interview with a public audience might encourage him to exaggerate. He was also basing his report on the accounts from villagers which may not be accurate.

4/4 A perceptive and balanced evaluation integrating all OPC elements with insight into reliability and motive.

19. Compare and contrast what Sources S and T reveal about the Račak massacre and the immediate response to it.

Both Sources S and T focus on the importance of the account of the massacre made by William Walker, as head of the KVM force. Source S says how his report 'went far to condition public sentiment for an eventual military campaign against Serbia' and Source T says how Walker described the scene 'as an unspeakable atrocity', also accusing the Serbs. Both sources also give the same picture of the massacre – that it took place in the village where dead bodies could be seen. Source S talks of the 'corpses' and Source T of the '45 bodies'. Both sources go on to talk of the international response following Walker's report. Source S speaks of the 'eventual military campaign' and Source T of the involvement of the ICTY.

There are also contrasts, however, Source S focuses very much on the words and actions of William Walker, whereas Source T talks more neutrally of the reports of the whole KVM mission and says that Walker's account was corroborated by other observers. Source C focuses very much on Walker's outrage and the impact that had on bringing about a military strike following the visit, whereas Source T only mentions the response of the ICTY as a follow up to Walker's visit.

5/6 Clear and valid points of similarity and difference supported by accurate evidence. Some minor imprecision and limited synthesis prevent full development across all comparisons.

20. Using the sources and your own knowledge, discuss how the Račak massacre was a turning point in the conflict in Kosovo.

The Račak massacre transformed Kosovo from a peripheral conflict into an international moral emergency, redefining the boundaries of sovereignty and intervention at the end of the twentieth century. What occurred in a single village in January 1999 was that forty-five unarmed civilians killed by Serbian security forces became the catalyst through which outrage, legality, and power converged to justify NATO's first major war fought in the name of humanitarianism.

The events at Račak shattered the last remnants of ambiguity surrounding Belgrade's conduct. Eyewitness accounts describing men and boys executed at close range (Source R) stripped away claims that the attack had been a legitimate clash with insurgents. The spectacle of bodies scattered on the hillside, relayed through journalists and observers, turned moral horror into diplomatic pressure. Within days, Western governments recast the violence not as internal repression but as an assault on international norms. This perceptual shift mattered more than the incident's scale: it converted the language of atrocity into policy momentum. The image of the destroyed mosque and homes (Source Q) made civilian vulnerability visible, while William

Walker's public condemnation framed the killings as a test of the League's late-century successor—the international community's conscience. As Nation notes, his outrage "conditioned public sentiment for an eventual military campaign against Serbia" (Source S), revealing how moral shock became political strategy.

That outrage quickly hardened into institutional action. Reports by the Kosovo Verification Mission documented forty-five victims, including women and a child, while Serbia's refusal to allow ICTY prosecutors to investigate (Source T) transformed calls for restraint into arguments for coercion. Western leaders, already frustrated by the failure of the Rambouillet talks, now possessed both a symbol and a pretext: Račak supplied the humanitarian rationale for intervention that diplomacy had failed to produce. Within two months NATO launched its bombing campaign, and by May 1999 the ICTY indicted Slobodan Milošević for crimes against humanity. The massacre thus functioned simultaneously as moral indictment, legal precedent, and strategic hinge.

Račak's significance lay not simply in what happened there, but in what it revealed about the late-1990s order that images of atrocity could reorder diplomacy more swiftly than law or negotiation. It marked the moment when humanitarianism ceased to be an aspiration and became an operational justification for war. In transforming a Balkan tragedy into a global test of conscience, Račak stood as the turning point where the vocabulary of human rights became indistinguishable from the language of intervention.

9/9 A perceptive and cohesive discussion that synthesizes all four sources with precise own knowledge to argue convincingly that Račak marked the decisive moral and political turning point in Kosovo, showing sustained analysis, integration, and conceptual sophistication throughout.